



Lightroom Classic:

Learn the Essentials

Lesson 03: Developing Basics

In this lesson you will learn how to use the Develop module to correct and enhance your photos: from cropping and white balance to exposure, contrast, and presence.



Before / After view in the Develop module

By the End of This Lesson You Will Know How To...

01

Navigate the Develop module workspace

Find the Histogram, Basic panel, and tools toolbar, and know what each section does.

02

Crop and straighten your photos

Use the Crop Overlay tool to improve composition and fix a tilted horizon.

03

Apply a camera profile

Choose the right color profile for your image as the starting point for editing.

04

Set white balance

Correct color casts using the WB dropdown or the White Balance Selector tool.

05

Adjust exposure, contrast, highlights and shadows

Use the Tone sliders in the Basic panel to correct brightness and bring out detail.

06

Use Presence sliders

Add texture, clarity, and color vibrance to finish your image.



The Develop Module Workspace

The Develop module is where you correct and enhance your photos. It is non-destructive, your original photo file is never changed.

Histogram (top right)

Shows the tonal range of your photo. Triangles in the corners are clipping warnings.

Basic panel (right)

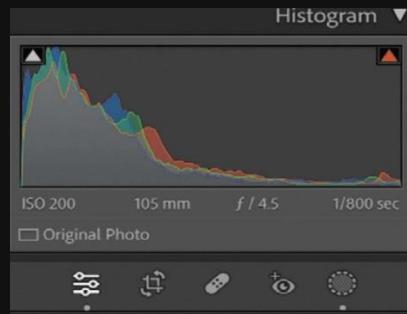
Your main editing panel. Profile, white balance, tone, and presence sliders are all here.

Tools toolbar (below Histogram)

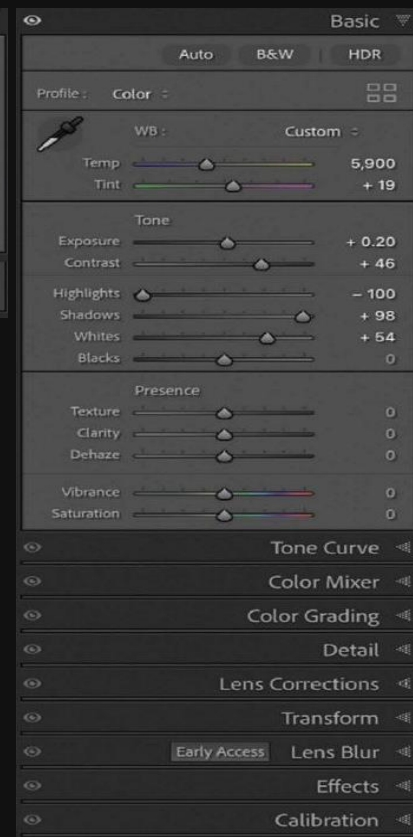
Crop, Remove, Masking, Red Eye, and Graduated Filter tools. Press R for Crop.

Left panel

Navigator, Presets, Snapshots, History, and Collections. Use Presets to apply looks quickly.



Histogram panel, shows tonal range and camera metadata



Basic panel, Profile, WB, Tone, and Presence sliders

Crop and Straighten Your Photo

1

Press D to go to the Develop module

Make sure you are in Loupe view. Press D on your keyboard from the Library module.

2

Press R to open the Crop Overlay tool

A crop rectangle appears around your photo. The Crop & Straighten options panel opens above the Basic panel.

3

Drag the corner handles to adjust the crop

Drag any corner or edge of the crop box. The area outside the crop darkens so you can preview the result.

4

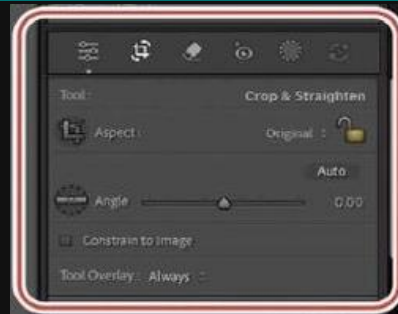
Press O to cycle through crop overlays

Rule of Thirds, Diagonal, Golden Ratio, and more. Use them as guides for composition.

5

Press Return or Enter to confirm the crop

The crop is applied. Press R again at any time to go back and adjust it.



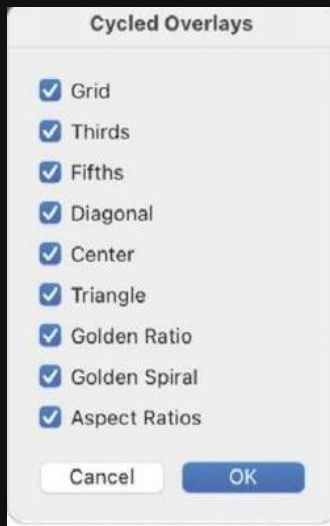
Crop Overlay active, Rule of Thirds grid visible



Left: Rule of Thirds | Right: Diagonal overlay

Crop Overlays and Straightening

Crop overlays are guides, not rules. Use them to help you make stronger compositions. Press O to cycle between them.



All 9 available crop overlays

Rule of Thirds

Divides the frame into thirds. Place your subject on the lines or intersections.

Diagonal

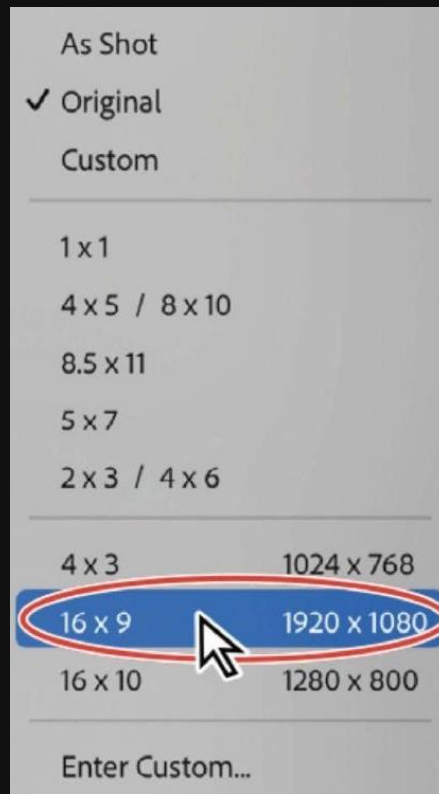
A line from corner to corner. Great for leading lines and dynamic compositions.

Golden Ratio

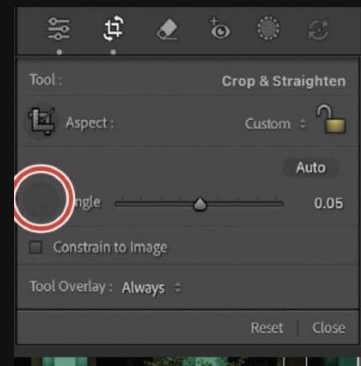
A curved composition guide used by classical painters and photographers.

Aspect Ratios

Shows common print and screen crop proportions side by side.



Aspect ratio options, 16x9 is 1920x1080



Crop panel

Straighten: In the Crop & Straighten panel, drag the Angle slider left or right to level a tilted horizon. Or drag along a line in the photo that should be horizontal.

Apply a Camera Profile

A camera profile sets the starting color interpretation for your photo. Think of it as the color mood Lightroom begins with before you make any adjustments.

1

Go to the Basic panel in the Develop module

Look at the very top of the Basic panel, just below the Auto, B&W, and HDR buttons.

2

Click the Profile dropdown

It may show Adobe Color, Adaptive Color, or As Shot. Click on it to open the menu.

3

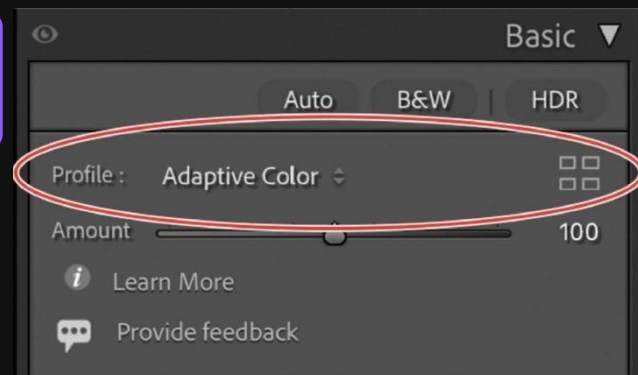
Choose Adaptive Color as your starting point

Adaptive Color uses AI to analyze each photo individually and apply the best starting color. It is the recommended setting for class work.

4

Click the grid icon to open the Profile Browser

The Profile Browser shows all available profiles with thumbnails so you can preview them on your photo.



Basic panel, Profile set to Adaptive Color



Profile dropdown showing all Adobe Raw profiles and Adaptive options

Camera Profiles: What They Are



Adobe Raw profiles

Camera-independent. Give any image a unified, neutral starting look. Adobe Color is the standard baseline.

Adaptive Color

AI-enhanced. Analyzes each photo individually to apply the best starting color. Recommended for class work.

Camera Matching profiles

Mimic the picture styles built into your specific camera. The number available depends on your camera make.

Creative profiles

Artistic effects using LUTs (color lookup tables). They have an Amount slider so you can dial in the strength.

Profiles do not change the Tone or Presence sliders, you still have full control after choosing a profile.

Set Your White Balance

White balance corrects color casts caused by different light sources. Fluorescent light turns photos green. Tungsten light turns them orange. WB fixes that.

1

Find WB at the top of the Basic panel

WB stands for White Balance. Click the dropdown next to it to see your options.

2

Choose the option that matches your lighting

Daylight, Cloudy, Shade, Tungsten, Fluorescent, Flash. For RAW photos, try Auto first and adjust from there.

3

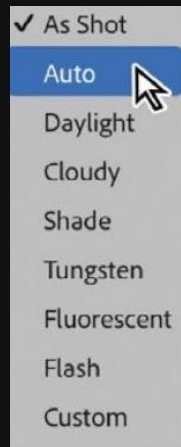
Use the Temp and Tint sliders to fine-tune

Temp moves blue to yellow (cool to warm). Tint moves green to magenta. Drag until colors look natural.

4

Use the White Balance Selector for precision

Press W or click the eyedropper icon in the Basic panel. Click on something in your photo that should be a neutral gray. Lightroom sets WB automatically.



*WB dropdown,
choose the option
that matches your
light source*

Adjust Exposure and Contrast

1 Find the Tone section in the Basic panel
Below White Balance you will see Tone with six sliders: Exposure, Contrast, Highlights, Shadows, Whites, and Blacks.

2 Drag Exposure to set overall brightness
Exposure affects the midtones most. Drag right to brighten, left to darken. Think of it as adjusting the base brightness of the whole photo.

3 Add Contrast to separate tones
Contrast pushes brights brighter and darks darker, increasing the difference between them. Start with +20 to +50 on most photos.



Develop workspace, Exposure +1.70 applied to the Havana street photo

Tip: Hold Shift and double-click any slider label to have Lightroom auto-set that single slider. Useful when you want Lightroom to make a quick guess.

Do not max out Exposure or Contrast. Subtle adjustments give better results. A photo that is +2.0 exposure will lose highlight detail and look washed out. Start small and work up.

Recover Highlights and Lift Shadows

Highlights and Shadows are targeted sliders. Highlights only affects the bright areas. Shadows only affects the dark areas. They do not interfere with each other.

1

Drag Highlights left to recover a bright sky

Pulling Highlights down (toward -100) brings back detail in overexposed areas like clouds or a bright sky. It does not darken the shadows.

2

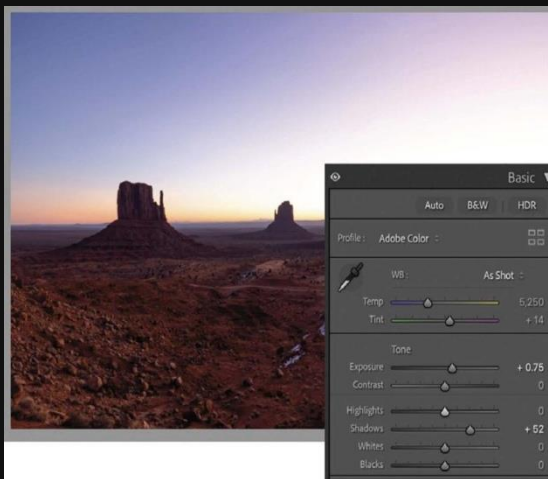
Drag Shadows right to open up dark areas

Pushing Shadows up (toward +100) reveals detail in dark areas like faces in shade or a dark foreground. It does not affect the bright areas.

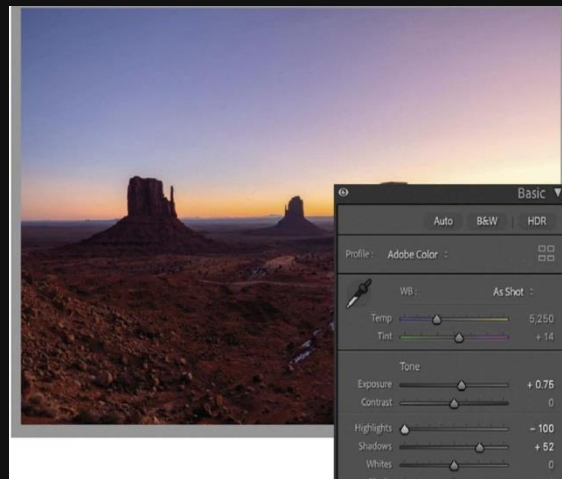
3

Press J to see clipping warnings

Blue areas are losing shadow detail. Red areas are losing highlight detail. Use this to judge how far to push your sliders before detail is lost.



Shadows +52 applied, detail opens in the dark foreground



Highlights -100, sky detail fully recovered

Set Whites and Blacks

Whites sets the brightest point in your photo. Blacks sets the darkest point. Setting these correctly spreads all your tonal information across the full range from black to white.

1

Hold Option and drag the Whites slider

The screen turns black. Drag right until you see the first small white or colored areas appear. That is your clipping point, back off slightly.

2

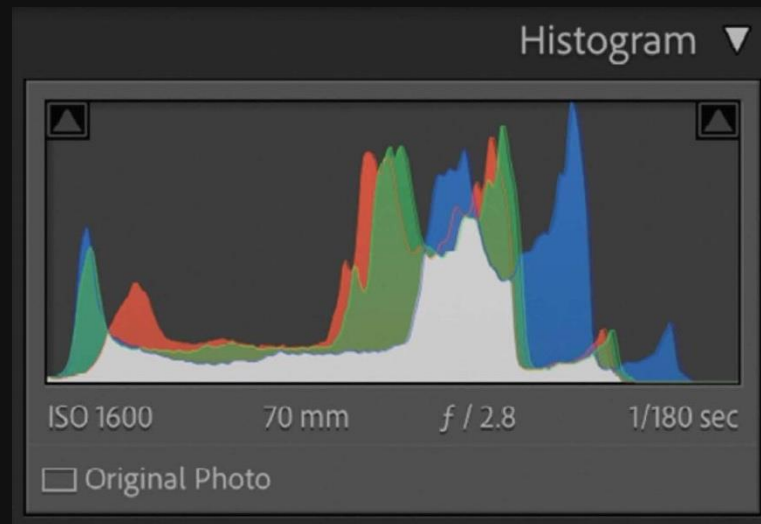
Hold Option and drag the Blacks slider

The screen turns white. Drag left until you see the first small black areas appear. That is your black point, back off slightly.

3

Check the histogram after adjusting

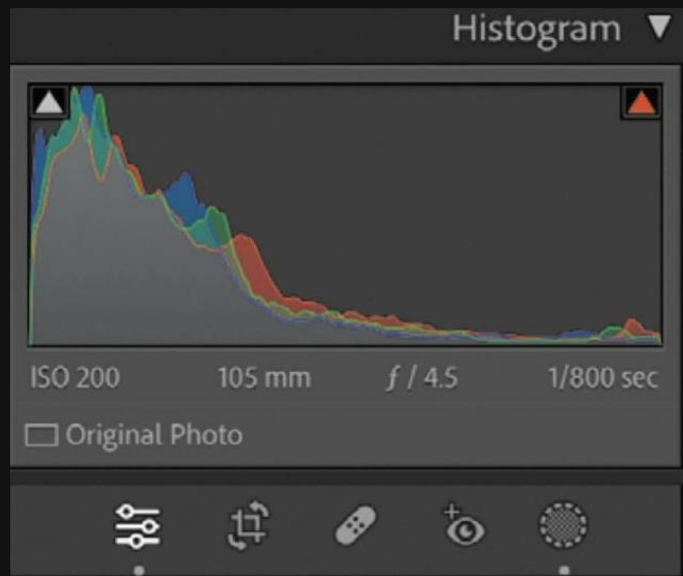
A well-adjusted photo has data spread across most of the histogram with no large piles against the left or right edges.



Histogram showing a well-spread tonal range, ISO 1600, 70mm, f/2.8

Professional workflow order: Set Exposure first. Then Highlights and Shadows to recover detail. Then Whites and Blacks to set the endpoints. Then Contrast last to taste.

Reading the Histogram



Histogram panel, color channels overlapping, camera metadata below

Left side = dark tones

Shadow and black detail. A pile against the left wall means clipped blacks, pure black with no detail.

Right side = bright tones

Highlight and white detail. A pile against the right wall means clipped highlights, blown-out whites with no detail.

Center = midtones

The bulk of most photos. Where skin tones, foliage, and middle grays live.

Colors = RGB channels

Red, green, and blue each have their own channel. Overlaps appear as mixed colors. A color-casted photo will show one channel pushed far from the others.

Triangles at corners

Clipping warning indicators. Click them to turn on the clipping overlay on your photo (or press J).

Add Presence, Texture, Clarity, Vibrance

Presence sliders are the finishing touches. Apply them after you have set tone and white balance.

1 Add Texture to bring out surface detail

Texture enhances fine detail like skin, fabric, bark, and feathers without affecting out-of-focus areas. Start between +15 and +30.

2 Add Clarity to increase midtone contrast

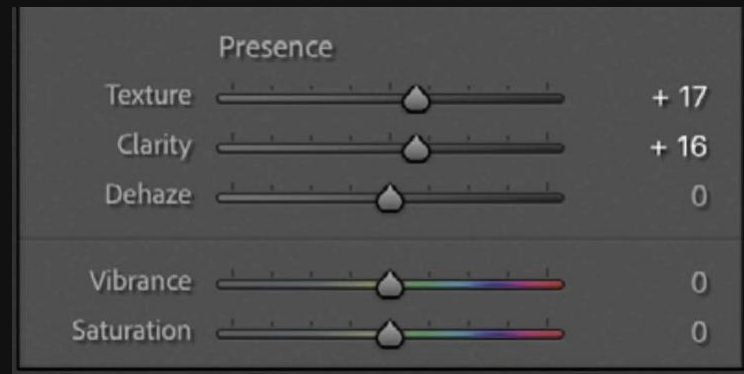
Clarity adds punch to edges and structure in the midtones. Too much makes photos look gritty and over-processed. Use sparingly, between +10 and +30.

3 Add Vibrance to boost color without oversaturating

Vibrance is a smart color boost, it protects skin tones and already-saturated colors while lifting duller colors. It is almost always safer than Saturation.

4 Use Saturation with care

Saturation boosts all colors equally and can quickly make a photo look unnatural. Rarely go above +20.



Presence section, Texture, Clarity, Dehaze, Vibrance, Saturation

Customizing the Develop Panel Order

You can rearrange the panels in the Develop module's right panel group to match the way you like to work.

1 Control-click any panel header in the right panel

A menu appears. Choose Customize Develop Panel.

2 Drag panel names to reorder them

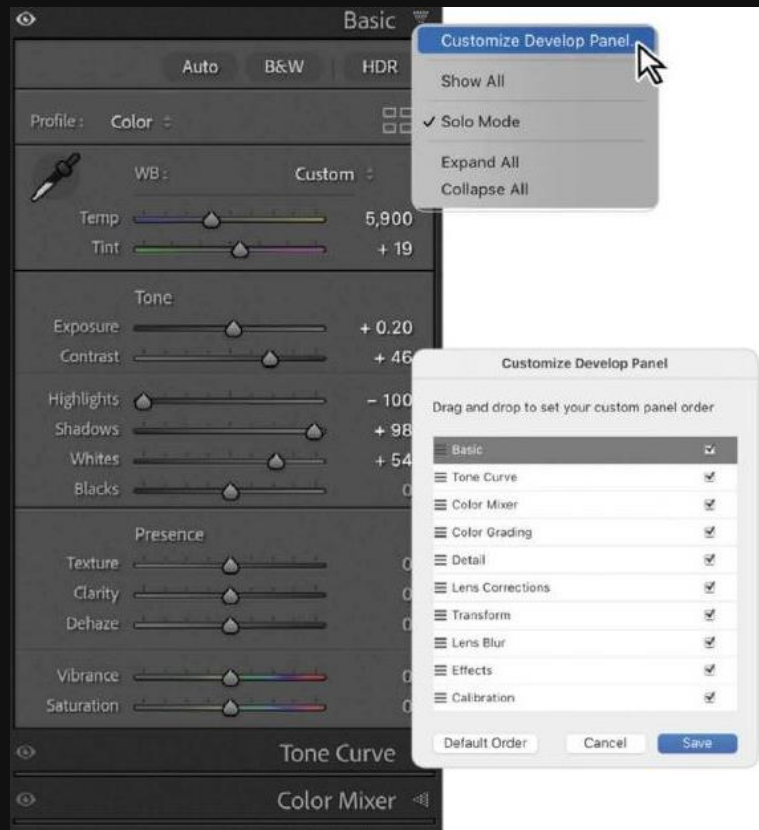
Drag any panel name up or down to change its position. Checkboxes toggle visibility.

3 Click Save and restart Lightroom

Your custom order is saved. Lightroom restarts and your panels appear in the new order.

To go back to the default order, open Customize Develop Panel again and click Default Order at the bottom left.

For class work, leave panels in the default order so your screen matches the lesson instructions. Only customize your own personal catalog.



Customize Develop Panel dialog, drag to reorder, checkboxes toggle visibility

Lens Corrections, Fix Distortion and Vignetting

Every lens has its own flaws, barrel distortion (bowing outward), pincushion distortion (bowing inward), and dark edges (vignetting). Lightroom can fix all of these automatically.

1 Scroll down the right panel to Lens Corrections

It is below Detail, Transform, and Lens Blur in the default panel order.

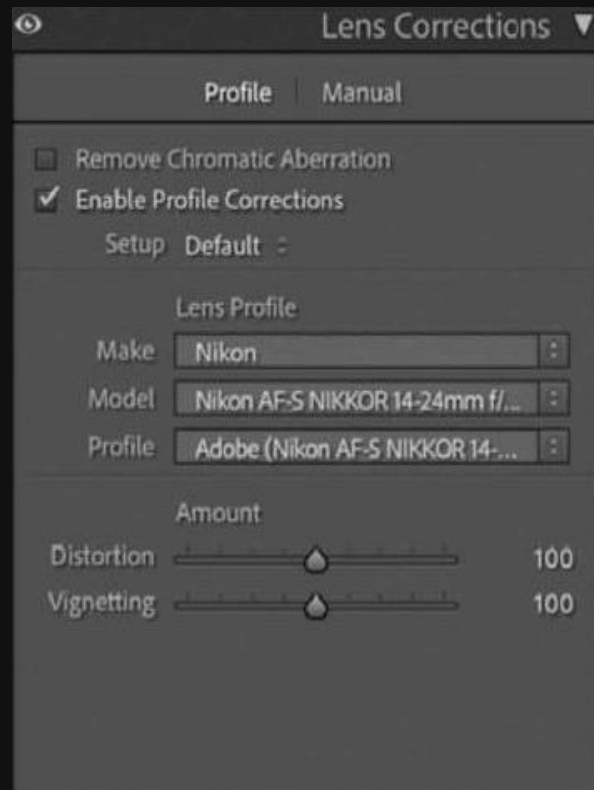
2 Click Enable Profile Corrections

Lightroom reads the EXIF data in your photo to identify your lens and automatically applies the correct distortion and vignetting fix.

3 If Lightroom cannot find your lens, choose it manually

Use the Make and Model dropdowns under Lens Profile. Choose the closest match if your exact lens is not listed.

For the Canon EOS R50 with the kit lens: Lightroom will usually find it automatically. If not, select Canon as the Make and look for RF-S 18-45mm or RF-S 18-150mm depending on which kit lens you have.



Lens Corrections panel, Enable Profile Corrections checked, Make and Model auto-detected

Key Vocabulary

These words will appear on quizzes and in class. Learn them now.

Develop module

The editing environment in Lightroom Classic where you correct and enhance photos.

Non-destructive

Editing that never changes the original photo file. All edits are saved in the Catalog.

Histogram

A graph showing the distribution of tones in your photo from pure black (left) to pure white (right).

Camera Profile

A color interpretation applied at the start of editing. Adaptive Color uses AI to optimize each photo.

White Balance

The color temperature and tint correction that removes color casts from different light sources.

Exposure

The overall brightness of a photo, controlled by the Exposure slider in the Tone section.

Highlights

The bright areas of a photo. The Highlights slider targets only the bright tones without affecting shadows.

Shadows

The dark areas of a photo. The Shadows slider opens up dark tones without affecting highlights.

Presence

A group of sliders, Texture, Clarity, Dehaze, Vibrance, and Saturation, that add detail and color depth.

Clipping

When bright areas blow out to pure white or dark areas crush to pure black, losing all detail.

Quick Reference: Your Develop Module Workflow

01

Press D

Go to the Develop module from the Library module.

02

Press R

Open the Crop Overlay tool. Press Return to confirm.

03

Profile

Set to Adaptive Color at the top of the Basic panel.

04

WB

Choose the WB preset that matches your light source. Fine-tune with Temp and Tint.

05

Exposure

Set overall brightness first. Press Auto to let Lightroom guess.

06

Highlights

Drag left to recover blown-out bright areas.

07

Shadows

Drag right to open up dark areas and reveal detail.

08

Whites / Blacks

Hold Option and drag to set the bright and dark endpoints.

09

Contrast

Add after setting tone. Shift+double-click for auto.

10

Texture + Vibrance

Add Presence last. Start with Texture +20, Vibrance +20.

Rate, Cull, and Export Your Best Photos

Rating is how you cull in this class. After editing a photo in the Develop module, press 5 on your keyboard to give it a 5-star rating. Only rate photos you are proud of and want to keep.

1

Press D to go to the Develop module

Open the photo you just edited. Make sure you are in the Develop module.

2

Press 5 on your keyboard to rate it 5 stars

You will see five gold stars appear at the bottom of the image. This marks it as one of your best photos.

3

Repeat for each photo you want to keep

Go through your edited photos. Press 5 for your best work. Press G to return to Grid view and move to the next photo.

4

Press backslash (\) to open the Library Filter Bar

In Grid view, press the backslash key to show the Library Filter Bar at the top of the grid.

5

Click Attribute, then click the 5th star to show only 5-star photos

Only your best photos are now visible. Press Cmd+A to select all of them.

5-STAR RATING: YOUR BEST WORK

5.0
RATING

Key Shortcuts for Rating

5

Rate selected photo 5 stars

0

Remove rating from a photo

G

Return to Grid view in Library

\

Show / hide Library Filter Bar

Cmd+A

Select all visible photos

To export: Filter to 5-star photos. Press Cmd+A to select all. Go to File > Export and choose JPEG as the format.

Your Develop Edit is Complete.



Your photo is corrected. Your edits are saved in the Catalog. Your original file is untouched.

YOUR NEXT STEP

Lesson 04, AI Assisted Editing →

Press D for Develop | Press G for Grid | Press E for Loupe | Press L for Library